

US Nurses

The enduring image of American women serving in Vietnam is that of the nurse. These women provided a broad spectrum of care for soldiers and civilians alike, and many emerged from the war traumatized by what they had seen.

◀◀ BEFORE

The US Army Nurse Corps was established in 1901, but American women had been providing care for troops in wartime since the Revolutionary War (1775–83).

HISTORY OF SERVICE

In the 19th century, **Clara Barton** was called the American Nightingale for her nursing of soldiers during the American Civil War, and about 10,000 US nurses **served overseas** during World War I.

At the beginning of World War II, women had to be white, unmarried volunteers, and graduates of a civilian nursing school to join the Nurse Corps. It had become **more diverse** by the end of the war, with Black American nurses in all-Black units. This diversity further increased in 1955 when the first man, Edward T. Lyon, joined the Corps.

Most nurses in Vietnam served in US Army hospitals, but the war also saw the service of US Air Force flight nurses and US Navy nurses on hospital ships. All treated a steady stream of patients with horrific injuries and serious tropical diseases, and many experienced difficult social and professional readjustment after their service.

The maximum number of military nurses in Vietnam at one time was about 900 in 1969 at the peak of the overall US troop deployment. As many as 6,000 US nurses were posted to Vietnam over the course of the war. Most of them were young, in their early twenties, and had clinical training but limited experience with the injuries and illness they encountered in the war zone. All were volunteers, and most were patriotically motivated, but in many cases also attracted by recruiting incentives that subsidized nursing training. By 1969, about 20 percent of nurses were men.

83 PERCENT of US women who served were nurses.

60 PERCENT had less than two years of training.